Study Plan — Step by Step

Goal: finish **CMU 15-445/645 Fall 2025** (all 24 lectures, homeworks 1–4, projects 0–2), this repo's OS, Networking, Version Control, System Design, Programming Languages and Concepts, and System Architecture domains, then **Low-Level Design, Testing & Reliability, Security, Cloud & DevOps, and Agentic AI** (Phase 8), contest practice, a small career track, and the **flagship project** (Raft KV store in Rust; full guide at the end of this PDF).
How it works: no dates. Do the **lowest unfinished step**, tick it, then move to the next. Time during military service varies, so the pace is open; only the order matters. **Friday** (the one day off) is for the long steps: 2–4h project chunks, virtual contests, flagship coding.
Out of scope: repo domains 1 (Data Structures), 2 (Algorithms) and 9 (Problem-solving and Coding). Contest-Practice stays.

The only exceptions: real deadlines

If one of these dates gets close, do that step first, then return to the sequence.

- Step 14: Knight-Hennessy — go/no-go (optional stretch) — **2026-10-06**
- Step 19: DAAD: document checklist + programme shortlist — **2026-10-30**
- Step 24: Book the IELTS test (needed for master's / Canada) — **2026-10-15**
- Step 34: DAAD motivation letter — first draft — **2026-10-30**
- Step 46: DAAD motivation letter — final; upload documents — **2026-10-30**
- Step 52: Submit the DAAD application — **2026-10-30**
- Step 137: ETH Zurich Excellence Scholarship (ESOP) — apply (window 1–30 Nov) — **2026-11-30**

Phases and checkpoints

Phase	Steps	Checkpoints
1 · Setup + SQL + P0	1–19	Step 10: P0 passes on Gradescope · Step 16: HW1 self-graded
2 · Storage + HW2	20–29	Step 24: IELTS booked · Step 26: HW2 self-graded
3 · P1 Buffer Pool	30–61	Step 52: DAAD submitted · Step 59: P1 passes on Gradescope · Step 60: flagship repo created
4 · Indexes + execution	62–76	Step 68: HW3 self-graded
5 · P2 B+Tree + concurrency	77–96	Step 96: Raft election runs in simulation
6 · Distributed DBs + wrap-up	97–104	Step 98: HW4 · Step 101: all 24 lectures · Step 102: P2 passes · Step 103: flagship M0 done
7 · Next	105–138	CMU P3/P4 + HW5–6 (105, 111, 121) alternating with every guide of domain 7 Programming Languages and Concepts (106–120, incl. design patterns), domain 8 System Architecture (122–129) and the rest of System Design (130–132); then contests, mock interviews, final sweep. Alternate with flagship M1–M8.
8 · Engineering depth + AI	139–184	One step per new guide: Low-Level Design (139–145), Testing, Reliability & Observability (146–152), Security (153–159), Cloud, DevOps & Infrastructure (160–169), Agentic AI & LLM engineering (170–183, ending with timed system-design mocks and a hands-on agent project), then a checklist sweep (184). Run each guide's C++ examples and say its interview answers out loud.

Rules

- Hours are estimates. If a step takes longer, that's fine; don't skip ahead.
- Never skip a project checkpoint (P0, P1, P2 on Gradescope).
- Short on time? Do a short step (a guide, a career step, a reading); the long ones wait for Friday.
- After step 104, alternate one Phase 7 step with one flagship milestone (M1 → M8).
- Keep your BusTub copy **private** (course academic-integrity policy).

Time by track (phases 1–6)

CMU Project	**29h**
CMU Lecture	**24h**
Flagship Project	**20h**
Career	**9h**
Repo	**8h**
CMU Homework	**8h**
Contest Practice	**4.5h**
Review	**1.5h**
Total	**104h**

Key links

- CMU 15-445 Fall 2025: schedule · assignments · FAQ · lecture playlist · Gradescope for non-CMU students: code **5R4XPZ**, school "Carnegie Mellon University"
- Repo: README checklist · Contest PDFs · Application tracker · Study-Plan folder

Phase 1 · Setup + SQL + P0

steps 1–19 · ≈20h

☐	1	CMU Lecture	L01 — Relational Model & Algebra Reading: Chapters 1-2 Tick: Relational databases (SQL)	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	2	CMU Lecture	L02 — Modern SQL Reading: Chapters 3-5 Tick: DQL, DML, DDL, Joins, Views	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	3	CMU Project	Setup: clone BusTub into a private repo, build (CMake + clang), gdb ready; join non-CMU Gradescope (code 5R4XPZ, school: Carnegie Mellon University) Follow "Creating Your Own Project Repository" + "Setting Up Your Development Environment" on the P0 page	1h	Project spec
☐	4	CMU Project	P0 C++ Primer — Task #1 (first pass)	2.5h	Project spec
☐	5	Repo	OS: Processes + Threads guides Tick: Operating Systems → Processes; Threads	1h	Guide · Threads guide
☐	6	Flagship Project	Flagship: Raft paper §1–§5 + play with the raft.github.io visualization Milestone M0.	1h	Raft paper · Visualization
☐	7	Career	Update LinkedIn: follow Career-Roadmap/CV/LinkedIn.md (headline, About, GSoC + ODC entries, projects, skills, honors) Do it in the order of section 12. The file has ready-to-paste text for every section.	0.5h	CV folder
☐	8	CMU Lecture	L03 — Database Storage I Reading: Chapter 12.1-12.4, 13.2-13.3	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	9	CMU Lecture	L04 — Memory Management Reading: Chapter 13.2-13.5	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	10	CMU Project	P0 — finish, run tests + make check-clang-tidy + memory-leak check, submit to Gradescope (make submit-p0) **Milestone: P0 passes on Gradescope**	1.5h	Project spec
☐	11	CMU Homework	HW1 SQL (DuckDB) — Q1–Q4 Tick: Databases → DQL / Joins	1.5h	Homework
☐	12	Flagship Project	Flagship: Raft paper §6–§8; write your own one-page Figure 2 cheat sheet Then read the Students' Guide to Raft	1h	Raft paper · Students' Guide to Raft
☐	13	Contest Practice	Contest PDF #1: CF Round 1074 (Div. 4) — virtual, solve A–D, then read hints	1.5h	Contest PDFs
☐	14	Career	Knight-Hennessy — go/no-go (optional stretch) ⏰ **Deadline 2026-10-06** Hard deadline: do it before the date even if earlier steps are not finished.	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	15	CMU Lecture	L05 — Database Storage II Reading: Chapter 14.8.1, 24.2	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	16	CMU Homework	HW1 — Q5–Q6, then compare with the official solutions	1h	Homework · Solutions
☐	17	Repo	OS: Thread synchronization (mutexes, semaphores, monitors) Tick: Operating Systems → Thread synchronization mechanisms (Mutexes, Semaphores, Monitors)	0.5h	Guide
☐	18	Flagship Project	Flagship: DDIA ch. 9 part 1 — linearizability, ordering guarantees	1h	DDIA book
☐	19	Career	DAAD: document checklist + programme shortlist ⏰ **Deadline 2026-10-30** Hard deadline 30 Oct: the DAAD steps (19, 34, 46, 52) must be done before it.	0.5h	Roadmap file

Phase 2 · Storage + HW2

steps 20–29 · ≈8h

☐	20	CMU Lecture	L06 — Storage Models & Compression Reading: Chapter 11.2, 13.6	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	21	CMU Homework	HW2 Storage — first half	1h	Homework
☐	22	Repo	OS: Scheduling algorithms Tick: Operating Systems → Scheduling algorithms (Fair share, EDF, WFQ)	0.5h	Guide
☐	23	Flagship Project	Flagship: DDIA ch. 9 part 2 — consensus; Jepsen consistency-models map	1h	Jepsen models
☐	24	Career	Book the IELTS test (needed for master's / Canada) ⏰ **Deadline 2026-10-15** Pick a test date that fits your service schedule.	0.5h	Roadmap file

☐	25	CMU Lecture	L07 — Hash Tables Reading: Chapter 14.5, 24.5	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	26	CMU Homework	HW2 Storage — finish + self-grade with the official solutions	1h	Homework · Solutions
☐	27	Repo	OS: Memory management (page replacement, mmap, buddy allocation) Page replacement (LRU, Clock) is the same idea as the CMU P1 replacer. Tick: Operating Systems → Memory management (Page replacement, Memory-mapped files, Buddy allocation)	0.5h	Guide
☐	28	Flagship Project	Flagship: DDIA ch. 5 — replication (leaders, logs, lag)	1h	DDIA book
☐	29	Career	Shortlist 5 P1 companies from the application tracker	0.5h	Roadmap file

Phase 3 · P1 Buffer Pool

steps 30–61 · ≈32h

☐	30	CMU Project	P1 Buffer Pool Manager — read the spec; work through the ARC algorithm on paper	1h	Project spec
☐	31	Repo	Databases domain: read SQL-DQL, SQL-DML, Joins, Normalization guides; tick what HW1 + L01–L02 covered Tick: Databases → Relational databases (SQL) sub-items	1h	Guide
☐	32	Repo	OS: Deadlock detection and prevention Tick: Operating Systems → Deadlock detection and prevention	0.5h	Guide
☐	33	Flagship Project	Flagship: DDIA ch. 6 — partitioning (range vs hash, rebalancing)	1h	DDIA book
☐	34	Career	DAAD motivation letter — first draft ⏰ **Deadline 2026-10-30**	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	35	CMU Project	P1 Task #1 — ARC replacer: implementation start	1.5h	Project spec
☐	36	Repo	OS: File systems; tick all finished OS checklist items Tick: Operating Systems → File systems (Journaling, NFS/SMB, Encryption, HDFS/Ceph)	0.5h	Guide
☐	37	Flagship Project	Flagship: Tokio tutorial part 1 (spawning, shared state)	1h	Tokio tutorial
☐	38	Career	Send 1 application (P1 list) with the matching CV version	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	39	Review	Checkpoint review #1: tick finished checklist items in the repo README; re-plan anything that slipped	0.5h	README checklist
☐	40	CMU Lecture	L08 — Indexes & Filters I Reading: Chapter 14.1-14.4 Tick: Indexing → B-tree, B+ tree	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	41	CMU Lecture	L09 — Indexes & Filters II Reading: Chapter 14.1-14.4, 24.1 Tick: Indexing → Bitmap indexing	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	42	CMU Project	P1 Task #1 — ARC replacer: finish + pass local tests	2h	Project spec
☐	43	CMU Project	P1 Task #2 — Disk Scheduler	1h	Project spec
☐	44	Flagship Project	Flagship: Tokio tutorial part 2 (channels, I/O, framing, select)	1h	Tokio tutorial
☐	45	Contest Practice	Contest PDF #2: CF Round 1062 (Div. 4) — virtual, A–D	1.5h	Contest PDFs
☐	46	Career	DAAD motivation letter — final; upload documents ⏰ **Deadline 2026-10-30**	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	47	CMU Lecture	L10 — Index Concurrency Control Reading: Chapter 18.10.2	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	48	CMU Lecture	L11 — Sorting & Aggregations Algorithms Reading: Chapter 15.4-15.5	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	49	CMU Project	P1 Task #3 — Buffer Pool Manager + page guards	4h	Project spec
☐	50	Repo	Networking: TCP/IP stack (OSI layers, TCP vs UDP) Tick: Networking → TCP/IP stack (OSI model layers, TCP vs. UDP)	0.5h	Guide
☐	51	Flagship Project	Flagship: tonic gRPC hello world; draft kv.proto + raft.proto	1h	GitHub
☐	52	Career	Submit the DAAD application ⏰ **Deadline 2026-10-30**	0.5h	Roadmap file

☐	53	CMU Lecture	L12 — Joins Algorithms Reading: Chapter 15.4-15.6 Tick: Joins	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	54	CMU Project	P1 — concurrency + debugging (gdb, sanitizers)	1h	Project spec
☐	55	Repo	Networking: DNS (resolution process) Tick: Networking → DNS (Resolution process)	0.5h	Guide
☐	56	Flagship Project	Flagship: write design doc RFC-000 (scope, API, non-goals, architecture, test plan) Use the architecture section of the flagship guide as the starting point.	1h	
☐	57	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	58	CMU Lecture	L13 — Query Execution I Reading: Chapter 15.1-15.3, 15.7	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	59	CMU Project	P1 — pass all Gradescope tests + format + leak check, submit **Milestone: P1 passes on Gradescope**	1.5h	Project spec
☐	60	Flagship Project	Flagship: create the public repo — Cargo workspace, CI (fmt, clippy, test), license, README skeleton Crates: kv-storage, kv-raft, kv-server, kv-client, kv-sim, bench. Commit RFC-000 to docs/.	1h	
☐	61	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file

Phase 4 · Indexes + execution

steps 62–76 · ≈12h

☐	62	CMU Lecture	L14 — Query Execution II Reading: Chapter 22	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	63	CMU Homework	HW3 Indexes & Filters — first half Tick: Databases → Indexing	1h	Homework
☐	64	Repo	Networking: HTTP (methods, status codes) Tick: Networking → HTTP protocol (Request methods, Status codes)	0.5h	Guide
☐	65	Flagship Project	Flagship: mini-lsm week 1 reading (memtable, SST format, merge iterators)	1h	mini-lsm
☐	66	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	67	CMU Lecture	L15 — Query Planning & Optimization I Reading: Chapter 16 Tick: Database design and optimization	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	68	CMU Homework	HW3 — finish + self-grade	1h	Homework · Solutions
☐	69	Repo	Networking: Routing algorithms; tick all finished Networking items Tick: Networking → Routing algorithms (Shortest path: Dijkstra, Bellman-Ford)	0.5h	Guide
☐	70	Flagship Project	Flagship: WAL — append with checksums, recover on start, tests Ties to CMU L21 (logging).	1h	
☐	71	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	72	CMU Lecture	L16 — Query Planning & Optimization II Reading: Chapter 16 Tick: Materialized views (partly)	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	73	CMU Project	P2 B+Tree — read the spec + Development Roadmap; Task #1 B+Tree pages	1h	Project spec
☐	74	Flagship Project	Flagship: memtable + flush to SSTable v0; Get/Put over storage	1h	mini-lsm
☐	75	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	76	Review	Checkpoint review #2: tick checklist items; re-plan anything that slipped	0.5h	README checklist

Phase 5 · P2 B+Tree + concurrency

steps 77–96 · ≈24h

☐	77	CMU Lecture	L17 — Concurrency Control Theory Reading: Chapter 18 Tick: Transactions; ACID properties	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	78	CMU Lecture	L18 — Two-Phase Locking Concurrency Control Reading: Chapter 18.1-18.3, 18.9 Tick: Isolation, Isolation levels	1h	Video · Slides · Notes

☐	79	CMU Project	P2 Task #1 finish; Task #2 point search + insertion (with splits)	3h	Project spec
☐	80	Flagship Project	Flagship: gRPC server (Get/Put/Delete) + CLI client, end-to-end test	1h	GitHub
☐	81	Contest Practice	Contest PDF #3: ABC 476 — virtual, A–E	1.5h	Contest PDFs
☐	82	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	83	CMU Lecture	L19 — Timestamp Ordering Concurrency Control Reading: Chapter 18.5-18.6	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	84	CMU Lecture	L20 — Multi-Version Concurrency Control Reading: Chapter 18.7-18.8 Tick: Isolation levels (MVCC)	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	85	CMU Project	P2 Task #2 — deletion (merge / redistribute); use the tree visualizer	3.5h	Project spec
☐	86	Repo	Version Control domain: Git guide + command reference, Bitbucket Tick: Version control System → Git; Bitbucket	1h	Guide · Command reference · Bitbucket
☐	87	Flagship Project	Flagship: Raft types + RequestVote/AppendEntries protos; node state machine skeleton Follow Figure 2 field by field.	1h	Raft paper
☐	88	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	89	CMU Lecture	L21 — Database Logging Reading: Chapter 19.1-19.8 Tick: Atomicity, Durability	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	90	CMU Project	P2 Task #3 — Index Iterator	1.5h	Project spec
☐	91	Flagship Project	Flagship: leader election with randomized timeouts + unit tests	1h	Open
☐	92	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	93	CMU Lecture	L22 — Database Recovery Reading: Chapter 19.1-19.9 Tick: Durability; Transaction Control	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	94	CMU Project	P2 Task #4 — Concurrency control (latch crabbing)	1.5h	Project spec
☐	95	Repo	System Design: Database Design and Optimization guide (ties to CMU L15–L16) Tick: System Design → Database design and optimization	0.5h	Guide
☐	96	Flagship Project	Flagship: turmoil simulation harness + first election test under random delays/partitions	1h	GitHub

Phase 6 · Distributed DBs + wrap-up

steps 97–104 · ≈8h

☐	97	CMU Lecture	L23 — Distributed Database Systems I Reading: Chapter 20.4-20.5, 21, 23.1-23.4 Tick: Partitioning; NoSQL databases → Types	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	98	CMU Homework	HW4 Execution & Planning — solve + self-grade	1.5h	Homework · Solutions
☐	99	Flagship Project	Flagship: log replication — first AppendEntries path	1h	Raft paper
☐	100	Career	Send 1 application	0.5h	Roadmap file
☐	101	CMU Lecture	L24 — Distributed Database Systems II Reading: Chapter 20.7, 22.9 Tick: NoSQL databases → Examples	1h	Video · Slides · Notes
☐	102	CMU Project	P2 — pass Gradescope + leak check, submit **Milestone: P2 passes on Gradescope**	1.5h	Project spec
☐	103	Flagship Project	Flagship: M0 review — update RFC, first progress post, set M1 issues Mark M0 Done in the Project milestones database, then continue with M1.	1h	
☐	104	Review	Final review: tick all finished repo checklist items; move on to Phase 7	0.5h	README checklist

Phase 7 · Next

steps 105–138 · ≈53h

☐	105	CMU Project	CMU P3 Query Execution (Tasks 1–2) + HW5 Transactions	1h	Project spec

☐	**106**	Repo	Languages: Programming paradigms (imperative, declarative, functional, OOP, procedural, event-driven, aspect-oriented) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Programming paradigms (7 items); Functional vs. Imperative vs. Declarative	**1h**	Guide
☐	**107**	Repo	Languages: Object-oriented programming (encapsulation, inheritance, polymorphism, abstraction, composition vs inheritance, overriding vs overloading) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Object-oriented programming (6 items)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**108**	Repo	Languages: Functional programming (lambdas, higher-order functions, closures, pure functions, referential transparency) + Lambda calculus Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Functional programming (5 items); Lambda calculus	**1h**	Guide
☐	**109**	Repo	Languages: Type systems (static vs dynamic, strong vs weak, nominal vs structural) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Type systems (3 items)	**0.5h**	Guide
☐	**110**	Repo	Languages: Error handling (exceptions vs error codes, exception safety, propagation, recovery) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Error handling (5 items)	**0.5h**	Guide
☐	**111**	CMU Project	CMU P3 finish + P4 Concurrency Control start	**1h**	Project spec
☐	**112**	Repo	Languages: Memory management + garbage collection (stack vs heap, manual vs automatic, tracing vs reference counting, mark-and-sweep, generational GC) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Memory management (3 items); Garbage collection (2 items)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**113**	Repo	Languages: Memory layout (stack/heap, data/code segments) + Virtual memory (demand paging, page replacement) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Memory layout (2 items); Virtual Memory (2 items)	**1h**	Guide · Virtual memory guide
☐	**114**	Repo	Languages: Concurrency (threads vs processes, sync primitives, thread safety, deadlocks, races, parallelism vs concurrency) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Concurrency (7 items)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**115**	Repo	Languages: Asynchronous programming (callbacks, promises, futures, coroutines) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Asynchronous programming (4 items)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**116**	Repo	Languages: Network programming (sockets, client-server, TCP/UDP in code, RPC) Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Networking (4 items)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**117**	Repo	Languages: Recursion (tail, mutual, anonymous) + Regular expressions Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Recursion (3 items); Regular expressions	**1h**	Guide · Regex guide
☐	**118**	Repo	Design patterns: Creational patterns Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Design patterns → Creational	**1h**	Guide
☐	**119**	Repo	Design patterns: Structural patterns Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Design patterns → Structural	**1h**	Guide
☐	**120**	Repo	Design patterns: Behavioral patterns; tick all finished Programming Languages and Concepts items Tick: Programming Languages and Concepts → Design patterns → Behavioral (also System Design → Design patterns)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**121**	CMU Project	CMU P4 finish + HW6 Recovery + L25 final review	**1h**	Homework
☐	**122**	Repo	Architecture: Client-server architecture (basics, communication protocols) Tick: System Architecture → Client-server architecture (Basics, Communication protocols)	**0.5h**	Guide
☐	**123**	Repo	Architecture: RESTful architecture (guide + reference) Tick: System Architecture → RESTful architecture	**1h**	Guide · Reference
☐	**124**	Repo	Architecture: Layered architecture (presentation, business logic, data access, cross-cutting) Tick: System Architecture → Layered Architecture (4 items)	**0.5h**	Guide
☐	**125**	Repo	Architecture: Service-Oriented Architecture (principles, advantages, challenges) Tick: System Architecture → SOA (3 items)	**0.5h**	Guide

☐	**126**	Repo	Architecture: Message queuing (basics, use cases, RabbitMQ vs Kafka) Tick: System Architecture → Message Queuing (3 items)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**127**	Repo	Architecture: Event-driven architecture (components, advantages, Kafka) Tick: System Architecture → Event-Driven Architecture (4 items)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**128**	Repo	Architecture: Microservices (guide + 76-question reference) Tick: System Architecture → Microservices; System Design → Microservices architecture	**1.5h**	Guide · Reference & 76 Q&A
☐	**129**	Repo	Architecture: Caching strategies (cache-aside, write-through, write-behind, stampede prevention); tick all finished System Architecture items Tick: System Architecture → Caching strategies (4 items)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**130**	Repo	System Design: Scalability guide Tick: System Design → Scalability	**1h**	Guide
☐	**131**	Repo	System Design: Distributed systems guide Pairs well with the flagship project (Raft, replication). Tick: System Design → Distributed systems	**1h**	Guide
☐	**132**	Repo	System Design: Object-oriented design principles; tick all finished System Design items Tick: System Design → Object-oriented design principles	**1h**	Guide
☐	**133**	Contest Practice	Contest practice — 2 virtual contests a week from the Contest-Practice PDFs (ongoing) Extra problems by topic: CSES Problem Set		Contest PDFs · by topic: CSES Problem Set
☐	**134**	Career	Mock interviews — 1 system design + 1 behavioral (STAR) a week Mock platforms: Hello Interview Exponent interviewing.io		Guide · Mock platforms: Hello Interview · Exponent · interviewing.io · Behavioral questions
☐	**135**	Review	Repo: final checklist sweep (domains 3–8 and 10)		README checklist
☐	**136**	Career	Re-run the application tracker; follow up on all applications		Roadmap file
☐	**137**	Career	ETH Zurich Excellence Scholarship (ESOP) — apply (window 1–30 Nov) ⏰ **Deadline 2026-11-30** Hard deadline: do it inside the window even if earlier steps are not finished.		Roadmap file
☐	**138**	Career	Keep applying: 2 applications a week from the tracker (ongoing)		Roadmap file

Phase 8 · Engineering depth + AI

steps 139–184 · ≈71h

☐	**139**	Repo	LLD: Object-Oriented Design Fundamentals (6 topics) Tick: Object-Oriented Design Fundamentals	**1h**	Guide
☐	**140**	Repo	LLD: Requirements and Domain Modeling (5 topics) Tick: Requirements and Domain Modeling	**1h**	Guide
☐	**141**	Repo	LLD: UML and Communication (4 topics) Tick: UML and Communication	**1h**	Guide
☐	**142**	Repo	LLD: Design Patterns in Practice (11 topics) Tick: Design Patterns in Practice	**2h**	Guide
☐	**143**	Repo	LLD: API, Persistence, and Concurrency Design (6 topics) Tick: API, Persistence, and Concurrency Design	**1h**	Guide
☐	**144**	Repo	LLD: Implementation and Review (4 topics) Tick: Implementation and Review	**1h**	Guide
☐	**145**	Repo	LLD: Classic Low-Level Design Interview Problems (13 topics) Tick: Classic Low-Level Design Interview Problems	**2.5h**	Guide
☐	**146**	Repo	Testing: Software Testing Foundations (6 topics) Tick: Software Testing Foundations	**1h**	Guide
☐	**147**	Repo	Testing: Backend and Distributed-System Testing (7 topics) Tick: Backend and Distributed-System Testing	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**148**	Repo	Testing: Logging, Metrics, and Tracing (7 topics) Tick: Logging, Metrics, and Tracing	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**149**	Repo	Testing: Performance and Scalability Testing (5 topics) Tick: Performance and Scalability Testing	**1h**	Guide
☐	**150**	Repo	Testing: Reliability Engineering (SRE) (8 topics) Tick: Reliability Engineering (SRE)	**1.5h**	Guide

☐	**151**	Repo	Testing: Production Incidents and Operational Excellence (6 topics) Tick: Production Incidents and Operational Excellence	**1h**	Guide
☐	**152**	Repo	Testing: LLM and Agent Evaluation & Reliability (6 topics) Tick: LLM and Agent Evaluation & Reliability	**1h**	Guide
☐	**153**	Repo	Security: Core Security Principles (4 topics) Tick: Core Security Principles	**1h**	Guide
☐	**154**	Repo	Security: Application and API Security (9 topics) Tick: Application and API Security	**2h**	Guide
☐	**155**	Repo	Security: Cryptography and Data Protection (7 topics) Tick: Cryptography and Data Protection	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**156**	Repo	Security: Authentication and Authorization (8 topics) Tick: Authentication and Authorization	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**157**	Repo	Security: Infrastructure, Cloud, and Supply-Chain Security (6 topics) Tick: Infrastructure, Cloud, and Supply-Chain Security	**1h**	Guide
☐	**158**	Repo	Security: LLM and Agent Security (6 topics) Tick: LLM and Agent Security	**1h**	Guide
☐	**159**	Repo	Security: Security Operations and Design Interviews (5 topics) Tick: Security Operations and Design Interviews	**1h**	Guide
☐	**160**	Repo	Cloud: Cloud Computing Fundamentals (5 topics) Tick: Cloud Computing Fundamentals	**1h**	Guide
☐	**161**	Repo	Cloud: AWS Compute and Application Hosting (5 topics) Tick: AWS Compute and Application Hosting	**1h**	Guide
☐	**162**	Repo	Cloud: AWS Storage and Databases (5 topics) Tick: AWS Storage and Databases	**1h**	Guide
☐	**163**	Repo	Cloud: Cloud Networking and Identity (5 topics) Tick: Cloud Networking and Identity	**1h**	Guide
☐	**164**	Repo	Cloud: Cloud Messaging and Eventing (5 topics) Tick: Cloud Messaging and Eventing	**1h**	Guide
☐	**165**	Repo	Cloud: Containers and Docker (4 topics) Tick: Containers and Docker	**1h**	Guide
☐	**166**	Repo	Cloud: Kubernetes Fundamentals and Operations (6 topics) Tick: Kubernetes Fundamentals and Operations	**1h**	Guide
☐	**167**	Repo	Cloud: Infrastructure as Code (IaC) (5 topics) Tick: Infrastructure as Code (IaC)	**1h**	Guide
☐	**168**	Repo	Cloud: CI/CD and Release Engineering (5 topics) Tick: CI/CD and Release Engineering	**1h**	Guide
☐	**169**	Repo	Cloud: Cloud Cost, Capacity, and Operations (5 topics) Tick: Cloud Cost, Capacity, and Operations	**1h**	Guide
☐	**170**	Repo	AI: LLM and Generative AI Fundamentals (8 topics) Tick: LLM and Generative AI Fundamentals	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**171**	Repo	AI: Prompt Engineering and Structured Outputs (8 topics) Tick: Prompt Engineering and Structured Outputs	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**172**	Repo	AI: Agent fundamentals 1/2 — autonomy levels, core agent loop, deterministic nodes vs. model actions, human-in-the-loop, workflows vs. agents Upstream guides, one file per item: read all 5 files in this step. Tick: Agent Fundamentals and Decision-Making (5 items)	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**173**	Repo	AI: Agent fundamentals 2/2 — planning, ReAct tool loops, reflection, short- vs. long-term memory, stop conditions Upstream guides, one file per item: read all 5 files in this step. Tick: Agent Fundamentals and Decision-Making (5 items)	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**174**	Repo	AI: Tool Use, Integrations, and Protocols (10 topics) Tick: Tool Use, Integrations, and Protocols	**2h**	Guide
☐	**175**	Repo	AI: Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) (13 topics) Tick: Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)	**2.5h**	Guide
☐	**176**	Repo	AI: Memory, State, and Context Management (8 topics) Tick: Memory, State, and Context Management	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**177**	Repo	AI: Agentic Frameworks and Orchestration (10 topics) Tick: Agentic Frameworks and Orchestration	**2h**	Guide

☐	**178**	Repo	AI: Multi-Agent Systems (8 topics) Tick: Multi-Agent Systems	**1.5h**	Guide
☐	**179**	Repo	AI: Production Reliability and Observability for LLM Systems (12 topics) Tick: Production Reliability and Observability	**2.5h**	Guide
☐	**180**	Repo	AI: Evaluation and Testing for LLM Agents (12 topics) Tick: Evaluation and Testing	**2.5h**	Guide
☐	**181**	Repo	AI: Security, Privacy, and Safety for Agents (10 topics) Tick: Security, Privacy, and Safety	**2h**	Guide
☐	**182**	Repo	AI: Agentic System Design Interview Practice (11 topics) Do each design as a timed 45-minute mock using the framework at the top; one design per sitting. Tick: Agentic System Design Interview Practice	**2h**	Guide
☐	**183**	Repo	AI: Hands-On Interview Readiness (10 topics) Build the mini project step by step (split it over several Fridays); keep the before/after numbers for your CV and interviews. Tick: Hands-On Interview Readiness	**8h**	Guide
☐	**184**	Review	Review: tick all finished items of LLD, Testing, Security, Cloud and Agentic AI in the README; re-run 3 weak interview answers per domain Phase 8 checkpoint.	**1.5h**	README checklist

Flagship Project — Raft KV Store in Rust

What: a public, Raft-replicated, sharded key-value store in Rust, like a small etcd or TiKV. It has:

- a gRPC API and a Go client;
- fault-injection tests and benchmarks;
- Docker + Kubernetes deployment.

Why: it goes at the top of every CV version and covers what CMU 15-445 and GSoC 2026 don't show: distributed systems, backend services, Docker/Kubernetes, observability and measured performance.

Time: there are no fixed dates, because the time available during military service varies. Milestone **M0** is 20 short steps woven into the step-by-step study plan. After step 104, work through **M1 → M8 in order**, alternating with the Phase 7 steps. Use Friday, the one day off, for the coding-heavy milestones. The total is about 244 hours.

1. Why this project (and not more CMU or GSoC)

- **CMU projects must stay private** (the course's academic-integrity rule), so no recruiter can see them. They also cover a single-node database only: no replication, no consensus, no cloud.
- **GSoC shows Rust desktop, FFI and IPC work**, but not services, distributed systems, Kubernetes, load tests or production metrics.
- **The job ads the CVs were compared with** (Canonical, Cloudflare, IMC) asked for distributed systems, cloud, containers/Kubernetes, Go and performance. This project adds all of them truthfully.
- **It builds on CMU instead of repeating it:**
  - lectures 3–7 and 21–22 (storage, WAL, recovery) become the storage layer;
  - lectures 17–24 (concurrency control, distributed databases) become the theory behind it.

Target CV bullet. Fill in the real numbers at the end:

> Built a Raft-replicated, sharded key-value store in Rust (own Raft implementation, LSM storage, gRPC). Verified linearizable under crashes and network partitions with Maelstrom/Porcupine. X ops/s and p99 Y ms on a 5-node cluster. Deployed with Docker, Helm and Prometheus/Grafana.

2. Rules that make it impressive

1. **Write your own Raft.** Use raft-rs or openraft only to compare against. Your own consensus code is what interviewers ask about.
2. **Public repo from the first commit**, dual-licensed **MIT OR Apache-2.0** (the Rust convention):
3. small, clean commits;
4. one issue per task;
5. a design doc (RFC) for every big decision.
6. **Every claim has proof:** a test, a benchmark or a graph.
7. **Deterministic simulation testing** with turmoil:
8. run thousands of randomized cluster schedules with injected faults;
9. replay any failure from its seed.
10. **Linearizability checked under faults** with Maelstrom (Jepsen) and Porcupine. Publish the fault matrix.
11. **An honest README:**
12. what works, the known limits and the benchmarks;
13. how to run it with one command.
14. **Ship in milestones.** Each milestone ends with a tag, a short post and an updated design doc.

3. What to know before you start

Topic	Why	Resource
Raft consensus	The core: election, replication, safety (Figure 2)	Raft paper · raft.github.io + visualization · Students' Guide to Raft
Distributed-systems course	Lab structure and the classic Raft bugs	MIT 6.5840 · Raft lab
Replication, partitioning, consistency	The vocabulary and trade-offs interviewers use	DDIA ch. 5, 6, 9 · Jepsen consistency models
Async Rust	Networking, timers, channels, tasks	Tokio tutorial
gRPC + protobuf	Client API and Raft RPCs	tonic
LSM storage engine	WAL, memtable, SSTables, compaction	mini-lsm · CMU lectures 3–7, 21–22
Testing distributed systems	Correctness under faults	turmoil · madsim · Maelstrom · Gossip Glomers · Porcupine · toxiproxy
Ops and cloud	Deploying and observing a cluster	kind · Helm · Prometheus · OpenTelemetry Rust
Performance	Credible benchmarks and profiling	go-ycsb · etcd performance · cargo flamegraph
Go basics	The client SDK	A Tour of Go

Topic	Why	Resource
Reference implementations (read, don't copy)	How production systems structure Raft	raft-rs · openraft · etcd raft · talent-plan

4. Architecture

```
clients (CLI, Go SDK, Rust client)
        │  gRPC: Get / Put / Delete / Scan / CAS
        ▼
  kv-server ── shard router (key range → Raft group)
        │
        ▼
  Raft groups (3–5 replicas each)
    leader election · log replication · ReadIndex reads
    snapshots · membership change
        │ apply committed entries
        ▼
  kv-storage: WAL → memtable → SSTables (LSM), compaction

  ops: Docker image · docker compose · Helm chart (StatefulSet)
       Prometheus metrics · Grafana dashboard · OpenTelemetry traces
```

Cargo workspace: `kv-storage`, `kv-raft`, `kv-server`, `kv-client`, `kv-sim` (deterministic simulation tests), `bench`. The Go SDK lives in `clients/go`.

Design decisions to write up as RFCs:

- Raft vs Paxos;
- ReadIndex vs lease reads;
- LSM vs B+tree (and the write amplification it costs);
- range vs hash sharding;
- joint consensus vs single-server membership change;
- exactly-once client retries.

5. Milestones (in order, no dates)

#	Milestone	Est. hours	Done when
M0	Prep + skeleton: papers, Tokio/tonic, RFC-000, repo + CI, WAL + memtable, gRPC Get/Put, Raft election in simulation (the 20 flagship steps of the study plan)	20	CI green; RFC-000 in `docs/`; election test passes under turmoil with random delays; Cargo **workspace** set up so reusable parts can become their own crates later
M1	Storage engine (WAL with checksums, memtable, SSTables + bloom filters, compaction v0, crash recovery) + gRPC Get/Put/Delete/Scan + CLI + criterion benchmarks	24	`kill -9` mid-write never loses an acknowledged write; first benchmark numbers committed
M2	Raft core: election, log replication, commit, persistence, conflict handling; deterministic simulation with partitions, drops, reordering, crashes, built as its own crate (`sim/`) with no dependency on the KV code	36	Every Figure 2 rule has a test; 1000 seeded random runs pass; any failure replays from its seed; the simulator crate has its own README and example
M3	Replicated KV: state machine, ReadIndex reads, client IDs for exactly-once retries, snapshots + InstallSnapshot, Maelstrom adapter	24	Maelstrom `lin-kv` passes on 5 nodes, including partitions
M4	Faults: docker + toxiproxy + tc netem (partitions, latency, loss, crashes, disk-full); history recorder + linearizability checker, written in Rust as its own crate and cross-checked against Porcupine	28	Fault matrix in the README, every scenario linearizable; each bug found has a regression test; checker **published on crates.io** with docs.rs docs and a blog post
M5	Scale-out: multi-Raft per key range, shard router, membership change, shard split/move, rebalancing	36	Add/remove a node and move a shard under load with no lost or duplicated writes
M6	Ops: small Docker image, compose 3/5-node clusters, Helm chart on kind, Prometheus metrics, Grafana dashboard, tracing	24	`helm install` gives a healthy 3-node cluster; killing the leader shows a failover on the dashboard
M7	Performance + Go SDK: YCSB-style workloads, batching/pipelining, flamegraph tuning, comparison with etcd	24	Benchmark report with ops/s and p50/p99 for 3 workloads, before and after tuning, plus methodology
M8	Ship v1.0: final README, architecture doc + RFCs, 2 blog posts, 3-minute demo video, CV/LinkedIn update, Show HN / r/rust, publish the reusable crates, open 5 good-first issues	24	v1.0 tagged; crates published; 5 labelled good-first issues open; all three CVs rebuilt with real numbers; post published; GSoC mentors asked for feedback

6. How to present it to companies

- **README:**
  - one-line pitch, architecture diagram, one-command quick start (`docker compose up`);
  - features table;
  - **fault-test matrix**, **benchmark charts** (ops/s, p50/p99, against etcd) and **known limits**.
- **Two blog posts:**

    1. "Building Raft in Rust: the bugs deterministic simulation found"
    2. "Benchmarking my KV store against etcd"
- **3-minute demo video:** kill the leader live; the cluster keeps serving and Grafana shows the failover.
- **CV:** the first item under Projects in all three versions:
    - General SWE: numbers + the Go SDK;
    - Systems: Raft and simulation testing;
    - Embedded: the WAL, crash recovery and the latency budget.
- **Interview story (STAR):** the hardest bug, a trade-off you changed your mind on, and what you'd do differently.
- **Share it:** a LinkedIn post at v1.0, r/rust, Hacker News "Show HN", and a message to the GSoC mentors asking for feedback or a referral.

7. Keeping it alive as an open-source project

Nobody will run a hobby Raft store instead of etcd, so the store itself won't attract many users. The **reusable parts** will, because other Rust developers need them. Build them as separate crates from the start and publish them:

Crate	Built in	Who needs it
Linearizability checker (main one)	M4	Anyone testing a distributed system or database in Rust. Porcupine is Go-only, so there is a real gap.
Deterministic simulator (seeded faults, replay a failure from its seed)	M2	Teams building any networked Rust service
Storage engine (WAL, SSTables, bloom filters)	M1	Lower demand (sled and fjall exist); publish only if it stays clean

What brings people to the repo: 1. **Write about it.** Posts like "How my own checker found a linearizability bug" or "Deterministic simulation in Rust from scratch" bring more visitors than code. Share them on r/rust, Hacker News and *This Week in Rust*. 2. **Publish on crates.io** with docs on docs.rs and runnable examples in each README. 3. **Keep it alive:** tagged releases, a `CHANGELOG.md`, `CONTRIBUTING.md`, a few "good first issue" labels, and fast replies to issues and PRs. 4. **Easy to try:** a 30-second "run a 3-node cluster" command and the fault matrix at the top of the README. 5. **Link it everywhere:** pinned on GitHub, LinkedIn Featured, and mentioned where it helps someone (for example Maelstrom and Jepsen discussions).

Done when: the checker crate has outside users (stars, issues or a dependent crate) and at least one PR from someone else.

8. Routine

- **Every session:** a small commit, then tick the step.
- **Every week:** update the design doc, add a note to `docs/log.md`, run the full simulation suite.
- **Every milestone:** tag a release, write a short public post, update the CV bullet.